

Chapter 152 - Part 1

Sun Chengcheng knew she was in the wrong here. After hesitating, she answered: "I'm not sure, but my father said I must attend tonight. Director, I'll come back as soon as possible."

Gu Yixue turned the paper in her hands several times, her cold gaze casually sizing her up.

Sun Chengcheng lowered her head, not daring to speak.

There was an inexplicable awkwardness and embarrassment, like being caught skipping class by a teacher back in school.

Gu Yixue wasn't someone who liked making things difficult for people, but if Sun Chengcheng left tonight, it meant all these crew members would have to stand by.

The progress delayed today would have to be made up on other days, but there were other things to do on other days.

Delaying one day meant losing over a hundred thousand yuan.

No one would be willing to approve this leave.

But it was the same logic as asking for sick leave during school—she could refuse to let her go, but Sun Chengcheng's mind would always be on that matter, her thoughts wouldn't be on acting, and she would definitely keep having NGs, wasting film.

Since they hadn't started work yet anyway, Gu Yixue stood up, pulled out a cigarette from her pocket, and went to the smoking area to light one.

She was thin but liked to wear loose clothes. Her black sweater swayed back and forth in the wind, the scarlet cigarette tip flickering in and out of sight.

Liang Shi watched Gu Yixue's silhouette, her mind rapidly calculating about this banquet.

She never believed in such coincidences.

Sun Chengcheng had a reason she had to go, and the first thing Xu Qingzhu did after returning to the country was also to attend this banquet.

Surnamed Qin.

Qin Lishuang.

The image of Qin Lishuang flashed through her mind, along with the scene at the art museum that day.

—Lu Jiayi!

In a flash, everything connected.

The system said she had already crossed paths with Lu Jiayi, which meant it wasn't a chance encounter.

And during these days, she hadn't met many strangers. Among these strangers, she knew almost all of their names.

Aunt Zhu and Yan Lin, whom she met at the art museum. Shen Fenghe and Kong Xiaoxiao, whom she saw at the restaurant that day.

The only one whose name she didn't know was the person beside Qin Lishuang.

Most importantly, it was Qin Lishuang's attitude.

Everyone knew Qin Lishuang was a crazy artist with no creative boundaries, and also the spoiled young lady of the Qin family. Because Old Master Qin liked her the most, no one in the Qin family dared to provoke her. Even the entire circle turned a blind eye to her behavior out of respect for Old Master Qin.

But that day, Qin Lishuang had shown a degree of respect toward that person.

And that person didn't look very old.

Yet her eyes were deep and unfathomable.

It could only be Lu Jiayi.

So this was the banquet where Lu Jiayi and Xu Qingzhu would meet?

And Xu Qingzhu had started having frequent dreams these past few days because the original book was correcting the plot line.

Even more so because by this point, Xu Qingzhu had already divorced the original host, and Lu Jiayi, as the official pairing, was supposed to appear.

Everything became clear.

Liang Shi stood there and had a brainstorming session.

Gu Yixue finished her cigarette and came back, casually saying to Sun Chengcheng: "Then you can go. Tonight we'll focus on filming..."

Before she could finish, Liang Shi said: "Director Gu, I also have something to do. I need to leave tonight."

Gu Yixue frowned, her gaze toward Liang Shi full of confusion.

A few seconds later, Gu Yixue sat down, her voice very soft: "Alright."

After saying this, she called to the assistant director: "Brother Gua, notify everyone tonight—we're taking a break."

"I'm sorry," Liang Shi apologized to her.

Gu Yixue showed no reaction: "Consider it a day off."

But everyone knew that this drama had only been filming for two days. Who takes a day off right after starting?

It was just Gu Yixue giving her face.

Sun Chengcheng immediately said: "Thank you, Director."

Gu Yixue didn't even give her a glance and said coldly: "This is the only time. There won't be a next."

It was said to Sun Chengcheng, and also to Liang Shi.

Chapter 152 - Part 2

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By the time Xu Qingzhu's plane landed, it was already evening.

Evenings in Haizhou City were very cold. The temperature had just dropped, and she felt the chill as soon as she got off the plane.

People were coming and going all around, extremely noisy.

The assistant helped carry her luggage while she walked ahead holding her phone.

Having been on silent for over ten hours on the plane, her phone was flooded with messages as soon as she turned it on. However, they were mostly from Sally and Lin Luoxi chatting in the group, plus some from work staff.

During this time, Liang Shi had only sent three messages.

【Babe, I'm going to film.】

【Be careful on your way.】

【Remember to let me know when you're back.】

There was some time between each message, which was still considerate.

If it had been before, Xu Qingzhu would definitely have been very happy to receive these messages. She might have already had the driver take the car to their production set to see her first. But now she just stared at the screen in deep thought.

In the end, she didn't reply to anything.

She had already had that dream more than once.

After getting drunk, she indeed couldn't remember anything. When she woke up the next day, her mood was still low, and her mind felt like it had been violently torn apart by something.

That day, Xu Qingzhu got up and went for a walk on the foreign streets. Because she was absent-minded, she was nearly hit by a car.

Even though it was only a near miss, her arm was still scraped a little.

It wasn't serious, but for someone with her sensitive skin, it looked quite obvious.

The assistant was terrified at the time, but Xu Qingzhu showed no reaction. She disinfected it, applied medicine, then lay on the bed in her room and slept again.

Once again repeating that dream.

She had always thought sleeping was a happy thing, but now it had become the thing she feared most.

But not sleeping left her with nothing to do.

Besides meeting clients to discuss business, she was just handling company matters online.

Occasionally, she would have hours-long overseas calls with Su Zhe, discussing the company's future development plans.

Minghui and Haiwei—both enterprises had their own merits.

Minghui, as an established jewelry company, had reputation and sentiment. Haiwei, having emerged from thousands of jewelry companies to become an industry benchmark, showed it had followed the trends of the times.

The two companies were no longer in competition now, and Su Zhe had helped Xu Qingzhu a lot in this regard.

Xu Qingzhu could even vaguely sense that Su Zhe was grooming her to be an heir.

Even though they weren't competitors, they were still different companies in the same industry. Yet Su Zhe didn't hide any of Haiwei's internal decisions from her. He even intentionally or unintentionally gave her pointers on how to grow and strengthen a company.

It seemed like he had the intention of merging the two companies.

Su Zhe had even used the example of federation and confederation to explain it to her before.

Xu Qingzhu knew that the younger siblings of the Su family had no intention of entering the company. One just wanted to focus on design, and the other was dead set on medical school. Su Zhe had no attachment to power and status.

Occasionally, he would tell Xu Qingzhu that if it weren't for what happened back then, Haiwei Jewelry wouldn't have gotten this far.

The implication was that if it weren't for trying to bring down Minghui, Su Zhe would definitely have been a carefree rich second generation, just like Su Meiqi now.

Su Zhe even made fun of himself, saying that Su Meiqi being like this now was purely inherited from him.

How come she didn't inherit even a bit of her mother's diligence?

Xu Qingzhu didn't refuse Su Zhe's kindness. Since Haiwei was willing to help Minghui now, she could save some effort. Moreover, in the fiercely competitive business world, having someone willing to lend a hand was absolutely beneficial without any drawbacks.

Furthermore, in Su Zhe's words, without Su Yao, Haiwei wouldn't have become what it was today.

So since Su Yao had a share in Haiwei Jewelry, Xu Qingzhu also had a share.

He didn't treat Xu Qingzhu as an outsider at all.

Even having taken over the affairs of two companies, Xu Qingzhu could still handle them with ease.

It was just that when it came to her own life, she felt rather powerless.

The effects of not sleeping well were far-reaching.

Within two days, she had already lost her temper at the assistant four times, scaring the assistant into being on edge. Even calling her for meals had to be done carefully.

This assistant was also temporarily hired, but she was quite smart with high education and high emotional intelligence. Xu Qingzhu admired her quite a bit.

In two months on the job, she had almost never lost her temper at her.

But now, in just two short days, four times.

The same frequency as her meals.

Not only was the assistant scared, but even Xu Qingzhu herself was scared. She always felt like she had some kind of illness.

She had already scheduled a comprehensive physical examination online.

She had completely forgotten what she talked about with Liang Shi after drinking too much that day, but she could still vaguely guess that Liang Shi knew something about her condition.

And knew quite a bit.

But she didn't even have the desire to ask.

There was always a voice reminding her that even if she asked, she would only get a deceitful answer.

Better not to ask.

Not sleeping well, not eating well—it made her mood extremely terrible.

Nothing could improve it.

Like right now, she simply didn't want to reply to Liang Shi's messages.

She didn't know what was wrong.

After taking the suitcase from the carousel, the assistant followed her out of the station. The driver was already waiting at the exit. As soon as she got in the car, Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes to rest.

But two seconds later, she opened them again.

She couldn't sleep. If she slept, she would have nightmares again.

This had truly become an unsolvable problem.

So, feeling rather bored, Xu Qingzhu opened her phone to go online. After logging into her side account, she found that a blogger she followed had posted on Weibo.

It was a daily post from Liang Shi at the production set.

The boxed lunch from the set and a fresh selfie of her.

The posting date was noon today.

She was quite good at fan service.¹ The photos she posted had no obvious Photoshop traces—it was a fake bare-face look.

Due to the plot requirements, her hair had been straightened, dyed black, and cut a bit shorter.

One could only catch a glimpse from the photos.

The two of them hadn't video called for several days because whenever they did, Xu Qingzhu would want to drink to numb herself.

Liang Shi had noticed this too, so she hadn't initiated any video calls.

It was as if an invisible rope was twisting the two of them, making neither of them feel good.

Xu Qingzhu liked this Weibo post, then tapped to view the full-size image.

1. Fan service / 營業 (yíngyè): In the entertainment industry context, this refers to celebrities actively engaging with fans through social media posts, selfies, and interactions to maintain their public image and fanbase. Literally means "doing business." ↩

Chapter 152 - Part 3

The boxed lunch from the set had two dishes and one soup, with very little rice—probably to avoid too many carbs so the actresses would look better on camera.

In the second photo, she looked exceptionally pure.

Despite having stunningly beautiful features, she had restrained all her sharpness, appearing quiet and well-behaved. She played a student quite convincingly.

Xu Qingzhu saved that photo, then scrolled through the comments.

Many were praising her for being beautiful, and occasionally some people asked what drama jiejie was filming.

But no one knew.

Even the news that Gu Yixue's new drama "Heart's Journey" had started filming hadn't been released.

Let alone who the two leads were.

After browsing through Liang Shi's fan service Weibo, Xu Qingzhu went to check the trending searches. There weren't any interesting topics.

However, Yang Shuyan had officially announced a new drama, and the official poster showed her in red clothes again.

This time Yang Shuyan was going to act in a period romance drama, paired with a female star from the same company.

Obviously, the female star's status wasn't on par with Yang Shuyan. The company was purely using Yang Shuyan to boost a newcomer.

As soon as the announcement came out, the trending topic section for Yang Shuyan was flooded by her fans.

Including the newcomer's and the company's topics—none were spared.

Fans were all cursing the trash company for being inhumane, making Yang Shuyan act in their own low-budget web drama while also having to carry and boost three newcomers. It was simply draining Yang Shuyan, and they hoped Yang Shuyan would withdraw from this drama.

But no one responded.

The fans' flame war escalated, and two or three trending topics related to Yang Shuyan were posted.

There was even one trending topic that, when clicked, showed a popular Weibo post that read:

[Instead of having Yang Shuyan boost newcomers, they might as well have Yang Shuyan act with Zhao Ying. At least both of them have solid acting skills.]

This Weibo post had thirty thousand likes.

Both Yang Shuyan's fans and Zhao Ying's fans fell silent.

But later, the two fan groups still tore into each other, continuing their usual style.

Xu Qingzhu was purely just looking. It couldn't even count as eating melons.¹ She browsed through all the trending searches, opened other apps, wandered around, then returned to the original social media app.

Liang Shi's messages had been re-marked as unread by her, but despite having OCD, she just couldn't bring herself to tap open the chat window and make that red dot disappear.

She hesitated all the way until arriving at the store. The stylist who would do her hair and makeup was already in position.

Only in the second before entering the store did she tap open the chat window and reply expressionlessly: 【Mm.】

Brief and to the point.

Xu Qingzhu handed her phone to the assistant, then quietly let the stylist do her hair and makeup.

The store was very quiet. She hadn't slept well last night. She had tried to catch up on sleep on the plane, but after closing her eyes for three minutes, she dreamed of that terrifying scene again.

After waking up, she had been reading.

Now with nothing to do, her drowsiness returned.

Perhaps because she was too exhausted, or maybe because she didn't actually fall asleep, she didn't have that dream again.

It was only a few minutes of rest, but it restored some of her energy.

The stylist had to apply three layers just to cover her dark circles—something that had never happened before.

Xu Qingzhu felt that strange things kept happening these days—the kind of strange that had no scientific explanation.

Soon, her phone vibrated slightly: 【Where are you?】

It was a message from Liang Shi.

Xu Qingzhu directly sent her location: 【Are you done filming?】

There was back-and-forth, but it had gained a layer of unfamiliarity.

Yet this unfamiliarity also came strangely.

After being frightened awake by the nightmares, Xu Qingzhu had also scrolled through their chat history in the middle of the night. It didn't seem fake at all.

They had once called each other "babe" and "wifey" so sweetly, and would argue for nearly half an hour over whether to sleep or not.

But when she looked through those sweet chat records, she didn't feel the same enthusiasm as before. She always felt like it was fake.

Like it shouldn't have happened.

All of this came too suddenly, catching Xu Qingzhu completely off guard.

And in this unfamiliar territory for Xu Qingzhu, she hadn't yet figured out a countermeasure.

Xu Qingzhu attributed this to: a vicious cycle caused by lack of sleep.

Liang Shi quickly replied: 【I took the day off today. I'm coming to find you.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【.....Why did you take the day off?】

Only after typing the words and sending the message did she belatedly realize it had a somewhat provocative tone.

Just as Xu Qingzhu was about to recall it, Liang Shi replied: 【I want to attend the banquet with you.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【.....】

She didn't recall the message above.

Combined with the ellipsis in this message, it felt like the entire screen was conveying two words—speechless.

Xu Qingzhu's first reaction was actually: 【Are you going to watch over me?】

Liang Shi replied: 【No, I just want to see you.】

Xu Qingzhu: 【.....Okay then.】

After sending this message, Xu Qingzhu didn't send anything more.

She always felt like this wasn't what she herself wanted to send.

She even tapped open that message, and after enlarging it, seeing the three words "want to see you," her heart was filled with joy.

This kind of joy couldn't deceive anyone.

Xu Qingzhu happened to see a water-blue gown. It was very beautiful.

She asked the stylist for that one.

The stylist said it was a couple's set. There was also a lake-blue gown—one was made of light gauze material, the other of matte silk.

So Xu Qingzhu had her keep both.

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1. Eating melons (吃瓜): Chinese internet slang meaning to watch drama or gossip unfold as a bystander, similar to "watching the tea" or being a spectator to drama. Derived from the image of casually eating watermelon seeds while watching something entertaining. ↩

Chapter 152 - Part 4

When Liang Shi arrived at the store, Xu Qingzhu had just finished her makeup and was getting her hair done.

She hurried in, but the moment she saw Xu Qingzhu, she didn't know what to say.

Still, she walked over. In the mirror, she could see her own somewhat stiff smile. "So beautiful."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "Thank you."

Cold and distant.

The secretary beside them was startled: Did they have a fight?

Weren't they inseparable just a few days ago?

However, since Liang Shi had arrived, the secretary only had the assistant stay to accompany Xu Qingzhu while she went back to the company to handle some matters first.

After Xu Qingzhu agreed, the secretary curiously glanced between her and Liang Shi several times, and finally left with a helpless sigh.

Her face seemed to say—such a good couple, how did they end up fighting?!

Liang Shi then sat beside Xu Qingzhu to get her hair and makeup done as well.

She still had her character makeup from the set, so she had to remove it first before redoing it.

By the time she came back from removing her makeup, Xu Qingzhu had already closed her eyes to rest.

Liang Shi glanced at her several times from the corner of her eye, then finally looked back at the mirror in front of her.

Only after Xu Qingzhu noticed that the gaze on her had disappeared did she open her eyes to look at Liang Shi—just a quick glance before looking away again.

The assistant was completely confused watching this—were these two playing some kind of couple's game?

The assistant, who had never been in a relationship, didn't understand and couldn't comprehend it.

However, both of them had good foundations, so makeup didn't take too long. It was just the styling that was more complicated.

Liang Shi still got curly hair, but it was temporary small curls. Xu Qingzhu got a braided style—one side braided, the other side in big wavy curls, showing off her elegance.

The two changed into the couple's set that Xu Qingzhu had picked out earlier and came out of the changing room at the same time.

When the assistant saw them, her jaw dropped and her eyes turned into hearts.

"Oh my god." The assistant exclaimed in surprise: "What kind of divine beauty are you two?!"

The assistant covered her mouth, shocked and excited: "President Xu, you and your wife should really both enter the entertainment industry!"

These two faces deserved to be admired by everyone!

The stylist was also looking at the two of them, her eyes clearly showing amazement as she nodded approvingly.

Liang Shi and Xu Qingzhu exchanged a glance.

Very quickly, Xu Qingzhu averted her gaze, with a hint of panic.

This hurt Liang Shi a little.

Chapter 152 - Part 5

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Xu Qingzhu really liked Liang Shi's look today. Whether it was the hairstyle, makeup, or the gown—everything was dancing right on her aesthetic preferences. It's just that she didn't know what was wrong with her.

Whenever she saw Liang Shi's face, those eyes, a bloody scene would always appear in her mind.

She could only look away.

But she was still moved.

The moment she saw Liang Shi.

She really wanted to kiss those lipstick-painted lips, and not just a brief taste.

Just thinking about it, Xu Qingzhu felt like fireworks were blooming in her heart.

But this happy feeling didn't last long before it was once again replaced by fear and irritation.

On the other side, Liang Shi was also preoccupied with worries.

The 33.34% probability the system mentioned would randomly fall on her, Xu Qingzhu, or Lu Jiayi. Although it wasn't honorable, Liang Shi hoped it would fall on Lu Jiayi.

That way, she and Xu Qingzhu could escape unscathed.

But looking at the situation, ninety percent of it had fallen on Xu Qingzhu.

When she looked into Xu Qingzhu's eyes, she could easily see a sense of torn contradiction.

It wasn't hard to tell that she was currently trapped in a struggle.

This struggle was causing her pain.

Besides the words exchanged when they met, the two had no further communication.

Even when there was brief eye contact, Xu Qingzhu would avoid it.

This interaction caused Xu Qingzhu pain.

So Liang Shi also avoided it.

However, in the car, Liang Shi finally couldn't help but move closer to Xu Qingzhu, her hand grasping hers.

A warm hand held her somewhat cold one. Xu Qingzhu was startled and turned to look, meeting Liang Shi's gaze directly.

Liang Shi squeezed her fingers. Her voice was still gentle but carried a slight tremble, along with a bit of cautious uncertainty: "Have you been having lots of nightmares again?"

Xu Qingzhu looked at her. Whether it was because she couldn't bear her gentle voice or her eyes that were about to well up with tears, her own eyes actually filled with tears too, looking aggrieved and pitiful.

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Mm."

The partition in the car came down.

The front and back seats were separated into two worlds.

The back seat belonged only to the two of them.

Liang Shi raised her hand to touch her face. "Are you still afraid of me?"

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together. The lip glaze on her lips looked like jelly.

She nodded and then shook her head, then tried to express her current feelings in clear words: "A little."

"It's a very complicated emotion," Xu Qingzhu said. "I want to get close to you, but there's a voice in my head saying you're dangerous."

Liang Shi didn't dare to smudge her makeup, so she could only gently stroke her face before lowering her hand. "But I'm right beside you."

Liang Shi said: "Feel for yourself—am I dangerous?"

Liang Shi stared at her very seriously.

After a moment, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said: "Dangerous."

Liang Shi was startled: "Huh?"

Xu Qingzhu pulled their clasped hands and placed them on her chest. "Just... you can feel it."

Xu Qingzhu's heart was beating extremely fast. Beneath that softness was her rapidly pounding heart.

Thump thump—thump thump—

As if it was about to leap out.

Liang Shi didn't know whether to laugh or cry. The atmosphere that had been so serious and tense just now instantly relaxed.

Xu Qingzhu said: "You're too good-looking."

Liang Shi: "....."

"The better-looking, the more dangerous." Xu Qingzhu's voice carried a few traces of tenderness and longing. "But I still like you so much."

She moved closer to Liang Shi, pressing tightly against her. "I've been so sad these past few days, wifey."

That term of endearment was like a valve.

Both of their breaths hitched simultaneously, and then they looked at each other at the same time.

Gently, slowly, drawing closer.

Lips met lips.

No need for too many words.

Liang Shi's hand landed on the open back of her gown. There was nothing on her fair back—it was held up only by the straps around her neck.

Her outer layer was still in the car, not yet put on.

Liang Shi's dress was relatively more conservative.

Both of them were mindful that their makeup had just been done, so they didn't go too far.

Only, Xu Qingzhu was now sitting on Liang Shi's lap.

Gown overlapping with gown.

Xu Qingzhu pulled away, panting, her eyes shimmering with rippling waves.

Chapter 152 - Part 6

"Did you miss me?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded honestly: "I did. I thought about you while eating, while sleeping, all the time."

"But I've been so sad these past few days." Xu Qingzhu wrapped her arms around her neck, brows slightly furrowed, and couldn't help but bite her lips. "Wifey~"

Liang Shi gently stroked her back, her slender fingers landing on her shoulder blades. "I know."

Although she couldn't feel Xu Qingzhu's pain, just thinking about it made her feel sad.

Even sadder than when she had returned to that world before.

"Baby." Liang Shi's voice was very soft, almost a whisper spoken right by her ear. "You just need to know that I will never hurt you in this lifetime."

She was like coaxing a child, making a sincere promise to Xu Qingzhu.

But Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "But there are many voices in my head."

It was like they were fighting—one moment this way, another moment that way.

That's why she felt the pain of being torn apart.

"You know something, don't you," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi nodded: "This is a kind of force majeure."

"How long will it last?" Xu Qingzhu raised her hand to wipe away the moisture on her lips, her fingertips covered in her lipstick.

"I don't know," Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu put her own finger in her mouth, wiping away all those red marks.

This action gave Liang Shi a huge visual impact. The hands holding Xu Qingzhu's back instantly tightened.

Xu Qingzhu's throat moved slightly. Her finger pressed on Liang Shi's gland as she leaned close to her ear and said: "Wifey, I really want to go home with you."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Aren't you still afraid of me?" Liang Shi said.

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "But I still like you so much."

Like you so much that even if you might kill me, I'd still be willing to go home with you.

"I want to—with you—" Xu Qingzhu whispered by her ear, her tongue tracing over Liang Shi's earlobe, making Liang Shi's ears instantly turn bright red.

Liang Shi lightly pinched her back, but without nails, there wasn't much force. That tiny mark disappeared in an instant.

Xu Qingzhu's voice was so low it was almost inaudible.

But all the warm breath went into Liang Shi's ear, making her ear itch, and her heart itch along with it.

Only then did Xu Qingzhu say, unhurriedly, almost word by word: "D, O, I."¹

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Liang Shi was nearly driven crazy by her teasing, yet she didn't say "stop messing around" like usual.

Or scold her for being ridiculous.

Because she could see in Xu Qingzhu's eyes that she seemed to be fighting against something with all her might.

She was trying to love Liang Shi in this way.

Liang Shi could feel it.

So she didn't use words to hurt Xu Qingzhu's heart anymore, to discourage her, to make her retreat.

Instead, she held her tight and whispered softly by her ear: "I want to too."

It had been quite a few days since those passionate moments.

Thinking about it, it was like eating until stuffed all at once, then starting to fast. This feeling wasn't pleasant.

It was the same for Liang Shi.

Before tasting the flavor of love, one didn't understand its beauty. But once experienced, one would know its mysteries and think about these things.

Especially having just gotten a taste, one would often crave that flavor.

After all, her wife was soft and fragrant, with lips like jelly—sweet and bouncy.

Liang Shi's mask of fake propriety was torn off as she held Xu Qingzhu the whole way.

To comfort Xu Qingzhu, she leaned close to her ear and called softly: "Wifey, be good."

Taking advantage of the partition, where the people in front couldn't hear or see.

It was even more tender and lingering than when they were in bed, making one's ears burn just listening.

Xu Qingzhu kept nuzzling against her, kissing her now and then.

Even fleeting kisses like dragonflies touching water could make tears well up in her eyes.

It wasn't until they were about to arrive at their destination that the two touched up each other's makeup again.

Wiping off what needed to be wiped, reapplying what needed to be reapplied.

After Liang Shi had reapplied her lipstick, just as Xu Qingzhu was about to put on her outer cardigan, she leaned over and placed a kiss on her shoulder blade.

The lip print landed on her shoulder blade, looking like a red butterfly from afar.

Appearing both glamorous and alluring.

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1. "D, O, I" - Xu Qingzhu is spelling out "Do I" as in asking "Do I (want to do it with you)?"
This is a flirtatious way of suggesting intimacy while being coy about it. ⇐

Chapter 152 - Part 7

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Sun Chengcheng had indeed come to this banquet to see Xu Qingzhu, and of course, Lu Jiayi as well.

According to her system, tonight was the best opportunity to capture Xu Qingzhu and Lu Jiayi's favor.

At 8:37 PM tonight, Xu Qingzhu would be accidentally pushed into the swimming pool, and Lu Jiayi, who had come to attend the banquet, would rescue her. At such a moment, Sun Chengcheng naturally couldn't miss out.

Of course, Sun Chengcheng had to stay nearby and jump into the water to save both of them.

She was quite confident in her swimming abilities. Even if she couldn't actually save them, she could at least earn some impression points.

The 20 favorability points from last time didn't seem to have had any effect, so this time she used 30 favorability points on Lu Jiayi.

To meet the conditions for these 30 points, she had done tasks until she nearly passed out.

Now she had absolutely no reserves left. This time, it was do or die!

She would definitely capture Lu Jiayi and Xu Qingzhu's favor and become close friends with them.

Otherwise, she would face the predicament of doing tasks until she passed out again.

It was really... infuriating!

Sun Chengcheng wore a bright yellow gown today, with beautiful big wavy curls. She looked quite elegant.

She arrived at the entrance on her father's arm. The attendant asked her to present the invitations, and she handed over both.

After entering, her father was still in shock. "Chengcheng, how did you get invitations?"

Based on their family's status, there was no way they could connect with the Qin family.

Although their family had some money, compared to the Qin family, they were nothing.

Chengcheng had also just graduated, so how could she...

Father Sun frowned: "You didn't do anything..."

"Dad!" Sun Chengcheng immediately frowned and said coldly: "What are you thinking? President Qin gave them to me. I saved her before, so she invited me to attend the banquet. What are you even thinking?"

After she said this, Father Sun immediately realized he had misunderstood and explained: "I'm sorry, Chengcheng. I was just too anxious. You're still young, and some people like to deceive girls like you. I was just worried about you."

"Dad, I know." Sun Chengcheng said: "But you don't need to worry. I got these through proper channels. Besides, am I the kind of girl who doesn't respect herself? Our family isn't short of money, so why would I do something like that?"

Only then was Father Sun reassured. "Exactly, my precious daughter would never be that kind of person."

Sun Chengcheng was flattered by the praise and got a bit smug. "Of course. Dad, go see who you want to meet here. Don't hold back."

Father Sun nodded: "Got it."

The two talked as they entered the banquet hall.

The Qin family's power wasn't really at the top tier in Haizhou City. The true top tier was the Shen and Gu families.

The Qin family could at most be placed in the second tier, and only at the tail end of it. Above them were the Zhou family and the Lin family.

The Zhao family and the Liang family were already in the third tier.

This was a rather strict division.

However, these rankings changed every year, so they weren't usually divided so precisely. For example, the Sheng family could have been placed in the second tier many years ago, but now they were barely hanging onto the tail of the third tier.

This world had always been ever-changing.

However, the family that Sun Chengcheng had transmigrated into didn't even have the qualifications to enter this banquet hall.

If Sun Chengcheng hadn't used her system, they wouldn't have been able to get in today at all.

After Sun Chengcheng had settled her father, she checked the time—it was just eight o'clock.

She then held her wine glass and drifted around the edges of the socialite circles, seeing if she could get to know any young ladies from prominent families.

Chapter 152 - Part 8

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Banquet hall, third floor lounge.

A woman in a white gown sat in a chair, looking up at the woman across from her wearing a dark green suit, and said coldly: "Who do you want to paint?"

"Xu Qingzhu." The other slowly uttered the words, then asked back flippantly: "What about it?"

The woman in the dark green suit wore a matching tight crop top underneath, her stomach flat—not looking at all like the belly of a woman in her thirties. There were even faint hints of abs.

It was none other than Qin Lishuang.

Qin Lishuang's lipstick color was very bright, a true red that looked quite seductive.

Her hair was meticulously fixed with hair gel, looking bold and sharp.

It was the very distinctive Qin Lishuang style.

Anyone who saw her would know she was the unconventional madwoman Qin Lishuang.

She pulled out a pack of cigarettes from her suit jacket and slid it over to the other person, saying airily: "This kid is quite pretty."

The person across from her was Lu Jiayi.

Lu Jiayi's fingers tapped on the cigarette box. She didn't take a cigarette and said flatly: "I don't smoke."

Qin Lishuang was startled. "I'm sorry, Miss Lu. I forgot."

Lu Jiayi slid the cigarette box back to her, fingers interlaced, and asked with a frown: "So?"

"My sister invited her here today." Qin Lishuang took a drag of her cigarette. "I kind of want to tie her up and take her back."

Madness showed in her eyes.

Even though Qin Lishuang had just warned her not to go crazy at the banquet their family was hosting, but what could she do?

After she had looked into Liang Shi before, she had really taken a liking to Xu Qingzhu's looks.

Mainly her cool voice and her cold, sharp gaze.

If she could become one of her paintings, how beautiful would that be?

Especially when she was tied to a chair, watching her hate to the bone yet be completely powerless—how thrilling would that be?

Qin Lishuang could barely contain herself.

She wouldn't suppress her nature just because this was a banquet hosted by Qin Liushuang, nor would she give up just because Qin Liushuang had warned her beforehand.

On the contrary, the more Qin Liushuang said that, the more excited she became.

So she came to tell Lu Jiayi.

Someone had to know about her plan, right?

That's what Qin Lishuang thought.

If she could bring those two wives together to her little room, that would be even better.

Although she had already painted Liang Shi before and had somewhat lost interest in her.

But buy one get one free wasn't a bad deal either.

Just thinking about it was enough to make Qin Lishuang's heart surge with excitement.

"You're too dangerous." Lu Jiayi glanced at her indifferently. "Perhaps what that person said last time was right. If you keep going on like this, the day the Old Master passes away, you'll be targeted by many people."

"Targeted" was quite a polite way of putting it. It should be insulted and beaten by many people.

The Qin family wasn't exactly a peaceful place either. The only reason Qin Lishuang dared to be so arrogant was entirely because of Old Master Qin's protection.

When Old Master Qin eventually closed his eyes and kicked the bucket, with no one to protect Qin Lishuang, Qin Liushuang would probably be the first to come out and tear her apart.

"What's there to be afraid of?" Qin Lishuang sneered. "He's not dead yet, is he?"

Lu Jiayi said coldly: "I'll pretend I didn't hear anything."

"You're not interested in beautiful women?" Qin Lishuang asked.

Lu Jiayi: "....."

Qin Lishuang laughed. "Right, you're someone who only likes power."

Lu Jiayi thought of the photo she had just seen. After a moment, she said: "The one in your photo is indeed quite nice."

"However..." Lu Jiayi paused. "The one I saw at the entrance of the art museum that day was also quite nice."